But who can tell the people of another country they should not fight for their motherland, for their independence and for their national dignity? I hope there is an open door to a just political settlement. Of course, we support you in that process and hope that it will take a practical and realistic turn.

However, 1985 was marked by an intensification of conflict. I hope this is not what the future holds. If you really want to withdraw from Afghanistan, you'll have my cooperation in every reasonable way. We've no desire to exploit a Soviet military withdrawal from Afghanistan to the detriment of Soviet interests. But the fighting can only be ended by the withdrawal of Soviet troops, the return of Afghan refugees to their country and the restoration of a genuinely sovereign non-aligned state. Such result would have an immediate positive effect on U.S.-Soviet relations and would help clear the way to progress in many other areas. . . .

The problems of superpower military involvement in local disputes are not limited to Afghanistan. Recent actions by the Soviet Union are most discouraging. What are we to make of your sharply increased military support of a local dictator who has declared a war of terrorism against much of the rest of the world and against the United States in particular? [I was referring to Qaddafi, whose responsibility for airport bombings in Rome and Vienna we had just established.] How can one take Soviet declarations of opposition to terrorism seriously when confronted with such action? And more importantly are we to conclude that the Soviet Union is so reckless in seeking to extend its influence in the world that it will place its prestige (and even the lives of some of its citizens) at the mercy of a mentally unbalanced local despot?